

So nearly there: Tokyo 2020 silver medallist Mirabai Chanu could only finish fourth this time. RITU RAJ KONWAR

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After the highs of Tokyo, the Indian contingent had flown to Paris with great expectations. The Indian Olympic Association president P.T. Usha had said that India could even improve upon the seven medals it won in Tokyo.

That didn't quite happen.

India, represented by 117 competitors, had to be content with six medals, one less than the tally from the last Olympics. With Neeraj Chopra being upstaged by Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem, India failed to win a single gold, which meant it could finish only 71st on the medals table.

If the ace athlete had bagged the men's javelin gold, as he did in Tokyo, the country would have finished a lot higher. India was 48th at Tokyo, where it came up with its best Olympic show ever.

India's hopes were indeed mainly about Neeraj, the shooters, the men's hockey players, the wrestlers and shuttlers. Though badminton failed to give India a medal (for the first time in four Olympics), the shooters and the wrestlers did well. By winning the bronze, the men's hockey team provided much joy.

It was not just in its strong events that India sent its athletes to Paris. There were also participants in less popular events.

In equestrian, for instance. Anush Agarwalla became the first ever Indian to take part in the dressage event at the Olympics.

The 24-year-old from Kolkata, who had won a gold and bronze at the Hangzhou Asian Games a couple of years ago, however, failed in his quest to make it to the medal round. He finished ninth in his pool of ten, scoring 66.444%. Only the top two were guaranteed to advance.

Deepika Kumari fared a lot better in archery. But the Olympics proved a disappointment yet again for the much-decorated archer from Jharkhand. For the second edition in a row, the 30-year-old's campaign ended at the quarterfinal stage; she went down to South Korea's Nam Suhyeon.

Deepika has won a staggering number of medals in international events – the World Cup, the Asian Games, the Asian Championships, the Commonwealth Games and the World Championship. But, the Olympic medal continues to elude her.

Bhajan Kaur and Ankita Bhakat also took

